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MINISTRY OF INFORMATION AND BROADCASTING

Staff: **6,908**

Wages and allowances: **Rs 102.51 crore**

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: **Rs 1,681.84 cr**

RATIONALE: To enable free flow of information besides disseminating knowledge and entertainment to all sections of the society, while balancing commercial needs and public interest. It is also the apex body for formulating rules and regulation relating to information and broadcasting, press and films.

REALITY CHECK: For almost 30 years now, successive governments have threatened and promised to disband this relic of control raj. Doordarshan and AIR can continue to work under Prasar Bharati.

In the Soviet era, for years Czechoslovakians did not know Martina Navratilova was the best woman tennis player ever. For them, Hana Mandlikova reigned in the tennis world. Complete control over all access to information was something the Soviets cherished. India was not far behind. For confirmation of Indira Gandhi's murder, we had to depend on BBC. I&B ministers notoriously spiked films—our only source of entertainment—for their own entertainment. What is this ministry doing in the era of the Internet, 24-hour news channels and FM radio? Well, besides running a Song & Drama division, it has been devising newer ways of retaining control to suspend that fashion channel, block news on radio or simply politicise film festivals.



The Government didn't have a clue that private enterprise had devised ways to connect people to the world of satellite tv. But as soon as the system was in place, it found reason to impose new controls. Do we really need this nanny? Isn't Prasar Bharati capable of monitoring news? Why should a ministry exist simply to give licences to new entrepreneurs—something that can be done by a board? And then throttle entrepreneurship by insisting on free feed for its channels in the name of national service? DD and AIR can function without state control, as briefly experimented during the NDA regime. The posse of officers parked in Shastri Bhavan can be put to better use in running community radios. Let market forces decide what's news and how information is broadcast or printed.

THE COALITION BANDWAGON

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Alchemy of Politics

MINISTRY OF CHEMICALS & FERTILISERS

Staff: **316+348**

Wages and allowances: **Rs 8.16 cr + Rs 7.23 cr**

Total plan and non-plan expenditure: **Rs 22,789 crore**

RATIONALE: To enable India to play a leading role in the global market; formulate and implement policies to achieve growth of these sectors; ensure mass availability, at reasonable prices, of quality pharmaceuticals.

REALITY CHECK: The ministry has had no real role in the march of the pharmaceutical and chemical sector. The